

Name: _____

Early Bronx History

Warm-up:

Label the 5 boroughs of NYC!

New York City Boroughs



Manhattan: ☐

Brooklyn: ☐

Queens: ☐

Bronx ☐

Staten Island: ☐

Mini-lesson: Native Peoples of NY

Use bullet points, abbreviations, and paraphrasing to help you capture important information.

1. First People	
2. Importance of Water	
3. Seasonal Movements	
4. European Contact	

Paraphrase:

“The Indigenous History of the Bronx River: A Story of Honor”

-Bronx River Alliance

“The people of the Eastern Woodlands did not consider themselves the owners of the land but ‘rather **stewards**¹ of the land who protected the resources around them,’ Bell said. When it came to taking oysters from the water, they would take the large ones so the small ones could remain and continue to contribute to the river’s **ecosystem**. They were mindful of how they treated the river to be considerate of how the next person may need it. They understood that everybody had a role and that it was their duty to maintain the **sympiotic relationship**² between themselves and the nature that sheltered them.”

-Excerpted from “The Indigenous History of the Bronx River: A Story of Honor”

By the Bronx River Alliance

Paraphrase in your own words:

¹ **Steward:** the job of supervising or taking care of something

² **Sympiotic relationship:** a relationship between two different species that can benefit both organisms

Slavery wasn't just a Southern problem, Bronxites had slaves

posted February 26, 2014

By Maya Rajamani

As he sorted through years of research collected by scouring³ countless manuscripts and original newspapers, Bronx historian and author Lloyd Ultan made an unexpected discovery — he had accumulated a book's worth of information about Blacks in the colonial Bronx.

Representations of slavery and slave-owning culture in the American South abound in the media, but Mr. Ultan's exploration of a lesser-known side of slavery's history has yielded a new book, *Blacks in the Colonial Bronx*. Published by the Bronx County Historical Society, the collection of historical documents, each prefaced with an examination and overview by Mr. Ultan, provides a narrative about the black experience during what Mr. Ultan refers to as a “formative” period in the history of the borough.

A man named Antone — freed in 1698 — his wife Diana and their three sons were the first documented⁴ freed black people in the Bronx. Slavery was not officially abolished in New York until 1827 — Mr. Ultan reveals in his book that slavery existed in the Bronx for centuries before it was made illegal. He unearthed⁵ documentation of the practice's existence in the Bronx in over 50 historical repositories⁶ scattered from Manhattan and the Bronx to Albany and New Brunswick, N.J.

“I wanted to give a narrative, give a story, about what the black experience was like and how they lived, what they did, what clothes they wore, what accomplishments they made and how they were treated, both good and ill,” said Mr. Ultan.

Most land-owning Bronxites, Mr. Ultan writes, owned one or two slaves who would sleep in the same house as the slave



Oloff Stevense Van Cortlandt was a wealthy Dutch merchant. His son, Jacobus Van Cortlandt began purchasing land in the Bronx in 1694, and gradually turned the family business into a wheat plantation with extensive milling operations. Enslaved Native Americans and Blacks were used on the Bronx plantations.

³ Scoured: searching through carefully

⁴ Documented: recorded or wrote down

⁵ Unearthed: Discovered

⁶ Repositories: An archive or storehouse

owners. But among the well known slave owners in the Bronx were the Morris and the Van Cortlandt families, who gave their names to Van Cortlandt Park and Morrisania.

It was the Morris family that had the largest number of slaves at any given time in the Bronx, with around 30 slaves at a time. One member of the Morris family served as the first American-born chief justice and first royal governor of New Jersey; another signed the Declaration of Independence. Mr. Ultan laughs when he explains the family's position in Bronx society.

“Have you seen *Downton Abbey*?” he asks. “They were upper crust.”

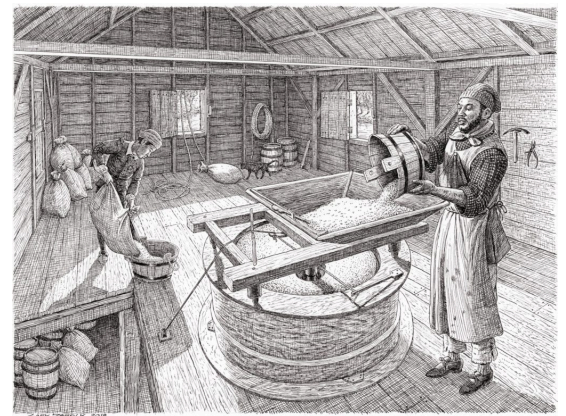
In some cases, Mr. Ultan describes a sort of slavery that, to an extent, left the slaves with some independence and a sense of respect within their slave-owning families.

He writes about a mill on the Van Cortlandt estate, at the southern end of Van Cortlandt Park's lake, where a slave named Pierro lived with his wife in relative independence from the Van Cortlandt family. Another slave, Leveallie, piloted a boat along the lake, transporting goods to and from the mill.

Blacks in the colonial Bronx, Mr. Ultan says, were integral⁷ to the borough's development, constituting between 10 and 15 percent of the population during the time in which slavery existed in the area.

“The blacks alongside the whites helped to develop the Bronx at the time,” Mr. Ultan said.

In the 1840s and 1850s, the Bronx, no longer a slave-holding area, became a hotbed⁸ of abolitionism⁹, with locales in the Bronx serving as stops on the Underground Railroad¹⁰. A lawyer by the name of Charles Van Doren had a secret room in his basement where fugitives could hide after they crossed what is now the Third Avenue Bridge. Daniel Mapes, meanwhile, hid slaves on his family farm, after which they moved on to New Rochelle and eventually New England and Canada.



⁷ Integral: Important to something or someone

⁸ Hotbed: A popular place

⁹ Abolitionism: A movement against slavery

¹⁰ Underground Railroad: a network of people, African American as well as white, offering shelter and aid to escaped enslaved people

Post-reading Questions

What are 3 important facts/details from this text?	Questions <i>What questions does this text invite you to think about?</i>	Choose an Important Quote from the text. <i>(Name #) + Analysis</i>
•	1. 2. 3.	“ ” What this quote shows is...

Vocabulary Parking Lot

What are some keywords that stand out? What new or unfamiliar words did you encounter?

Central Idea

What was the **message** of the text? **Why** do you think the author wrote this text?